



THE ONE THING

The Surprisingly Simple Truth
behind Extraordinary Results

Gary Keller (with Jay Papasan)

The Big "So What" ???

Keller identified that there's ONE Thing that's behind every successful person or organization. He shows **how we can concurrently have less and more, to get extra-ordinary results and lead an extra-ordinary life:**

- **Less** distractions and things to do
- **More** productivity, income, satisfaction, time etc.

The ONE Thing



The key idea in the book is to focus on this question: **What's the ONE Thing you can do, such that by doing it, everything else will be easier or unnecessary?**

Going Small

Those who truly succeed understand what it means to go small:

- Ignore all the things you could do. Just do what you should do.
- Not all things matter equally. Find the things that matter most.
- Extraordinary results are directly determined by how narrow you can make your focus.

The Domino Effect: Harness the Power of Geometric Progression



If you started with a 2-inch domino, and increased the size of each subsequent domino by 50%, the 57th domino would practically bridge the distance between the earth and the moon. That's the power of geometric progression.

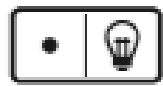
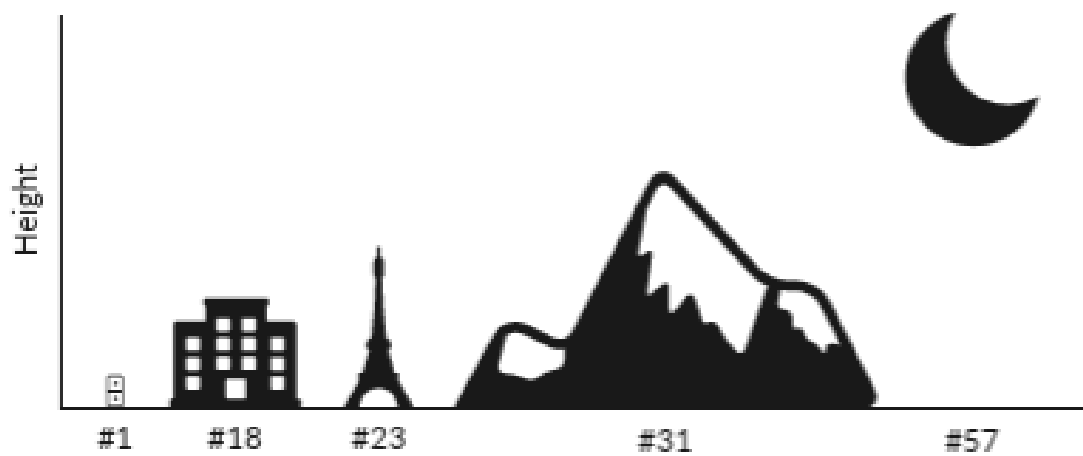
KEY QUOTES

"If you try to do just ONE Thing, the right ONE Thing, you could wind up with everything you ever wanted."

*"Be like a postage stamp – stick to one thing until you get there."
- Josh Billings -*

"When you go as small as possible, you'll be staring at one thing. And that's the point."

"You need to be doing fewer things for more effect instead of doing more things with side effects."



To create the same geometric effect in your life, **you need to find the lead domino.** Keep working at it. When you finally knock it over, the dominoes behind it would be ready to fall or have already fallen down.

Success Leaves Clues

The One Thing applies to success in all aspects of business and life:



One Product/ Service: Companies that are extraordinarily successful always have 1 signature product or service e.g. KFC's secret chicken recipe, Google's search.



One Person: No one is self-made. Every successful person (e.g. Walt Disney, Albert Einstein, Oprah Winfrey) has that 1 person who made all the difference, be it guiding him/her in the right direction or lending a helping hand at a pivotal point.



One Passion/ Skill: Extraordinarily successful people have one intense passion or ability that stands out, defines and drives them.

Banishing the 6 Lies of Success



Today, we have access to more information than ever before, but much of these information are not necessarily true or accurate. However, when myths and mistruths are repeated often enough, they start to feel familiar, we start to believe them and base important decisions on them. According to Keller, **there are 6 lies of success that need to be banished before we can embrace success.**

KEY QUOTES

"Getting extraordinary results is all about creating a domino effect in your life."

"The key is over time. Success is built sequentially. It's one thing at a time."

"If today your company doesn't know what its ONE Thing is, then the company's ONE Thing is to find out."

"Applying the ONE Thing to your work - and in your life - is the simplest and smartest thing you can do to propel yourself toward the success you want."

"It ain't what you don't know that gets you into trouble. It's what you know for sure that just ain't so."

- Mark Twain -

"Buying into the ONE Thing becomes difficult because we've unfortunately bought into too many others - and more often than not those "other things" muddle our thinking, misguide our actions, and sidetrack our success."

1. Everything Matters Equally

20% → 80%

Most of us face complex problems without a clear formula for good decision-making. When we feel overwhelmed, we tend to fall back on familiar and comfortable (but ineffective) ways of making decisions. The Pareto Principle (or 80/20 rule) says that the minority of your efforts generates the majority of your results.

Keller recommends applying the Extreme Pareto principle:

 **Go small.** Don't get trapped trying to finish everything on your to-do list. Take time out to prioritize and do what really matters - convert your to-do-list to a success list, by **prioritizing the "should do" over "could do" items.**

 **Go extreme.** Take the Pareto Principle to the extreme. **Keep zooming in on the top 20% until you end up with the essential ONE thing.**

 **Say no to everything else until your most important work is done.**

2. Multitasking Gets More Done



Many people have the false impression that multitasking helps them to accomplish more in less time. The opposite is true. Research shows that **multitasking leads to more mistakes, poorer choices, and greater stress:**

 **Task-switching costs you.** A juggler doesn't really multi-task - he catches and throws the balls individually in rapid succession, i.e. he is task-switching. Likewise, when we are "multitasking", we are usually only task-switching. Our brain can only focus on one thing at a time. **Each time we switch tasks, we need to re-orientate to the "rules" for the new task, losing time and energy in the process.**

 **Multi-tasking divides our attention** over the various tasks. It reduces our effectiveness for each task.

 We expect professionals like pilots and surgeons to focus fully on their tasks. We should likewise **give our most important work our undivided attention.**

KEY QUOTES

"Activity is often unrelated to productivity, and busyness rarely takes care of business."

"To-do lists tend to be long; success lists are short. One pulls you in all directions; the other aims you in a specific direction."

*"Many things may be important, but only one can be the most important."
- Ross Garber -*

"The truth is multitasking is neither efficient nor effective... When you try to do two things at once, you either can't or won't do either well."

"It's not that we have too little time to do all the things we need to do, it's that we feel the need to do too many things in the time we have."

3. We Need To Live A Disciplined Life



Disciplining yourself means training yourself to act in a specific way, or to form a habit. Hence, **we don't need to be disciplined all the time. We just need selected discipline to form the right habits:**



Don't be a disciplined person. Be a person of powerful habits. You just need to identify the right habit to cultivate, and have enough discipline to do it long enough to build that desired habit. Michael Phelps, for example, developed the winning habit of spending at least 6 hours a day in water, swimming 365 days a year.



Build 1 habit at a time. Over time, you can acquire more habits.



Give the habit enough time to form. On average, it takes 66 days to acquire a new habit (many self-help sources recommend 21 days, but modern science suggests it takes longer). The good news is, once a new behaviour becomes a habit, it takes less discipline to maintain.

4. Willpower Can Be Summoned Whenever Needed



Most of us have heard of the proverb "where there's a will, there's a way." While willpower is an important ingredient for success, it isn't something we can summon as and when we want.



Don't spread your willpower too thin. Willpower is like a battery – it has limited life and gets depleted with use. However, it can be recharged, when given downtime to recover. Use of willpower also consumes actual calories - Foods like complex carbohydrates and proteins that elevate blood sugar levels evenly are hence ideal for high-achievers.



Monitor your fuel gauge: When our willpower runs out, we will revert to our default settings, which typically means average results.

Hence, recognize that willpower is a resource that gets used up, reserve it for what's most important, and replenish it when it's low.

KEY QUOTES

"Success is about doing the right thing, not about doing everything right...The trick to success is to choose the right habit and bring just enough discipline to establish it."

"Success is actually a short race – a sprint fueled by discipline just long enough for habit to kick in and take over."

"Those with the right habits seem to do better than others. They're doing the most important thing regularly and, as a result, everything else is easier."

"Willpower is like a fast-twitch muscle that gets tired and needs rest. It's incredibly powerful, but it has no endurance."

"When you use (your willpower) first on what matters most, you can always count on it."

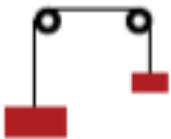


Time your task: Willpower gets sapped throughout the day when we focus our attention, suppress our feelings and impulses, or modify our behaviours to achieve goals. To get the most out of your day, do your most important work early.

5. We should live a Balanced Life



The idea of having enough time for everything sounds appealing. However, **when we give time and focus to what matters, it takes time away from lesser priorities, and we automatically go out of balance.** Trying to take a middle position means we make extraordinary commitments to nothing, hence achieve mediocre results on all fronts.



The solution is hence not to live a balanced life, but to apply counterbalance, i.e. never go so far that you cannot find your way back.

Identify the extraordinary result that matters most to you, and give it all the time it requires. Allow yourself to get out of balance, and use infrequent counterbalancing to address other priorities. Different goals and approaches are required to counter-balance work vs. your personal life:



For work, identify the ONE Thing that must be mastered. Make it ok to prioritize that one thing above other work priorities (i.e. be out of balance) for long periods of time.



For personal life, there are multiple areas that require a minimum level of attention for you to feel that you "have a life". Develop self-awareness and don't allow yourself to go out of balance for too long in any area without counterbalancing.

6. Big is bad



People tend to associate big results with complicated, difficult, complex processes, and feel overwhelmed and intimidated before they even embark on the journey. To avoid failure, they settle on what is comfortable and within reach.

KEY QUOTES

"Purpose, meaning, significance – these are what make a successful life. Seek them out and you will most certainly live your life out of balance."

"In your effort to attend to all things, everything gets short-changed and nothing gets its due."

"The reason we shouldn't pursue balance is that the magic never happens in the middle; magic happens at the extremes."

"Whether or not to go out of balance isn't really the question. The question is: 'Do you go short or long?'"

"When you're supposed to be working, work, and when you're supposed to be playing, play. It's a weird tightrope you're walking, but it's only when you get your priorities mixed up that things fall apart."

"No one knows their ultimate ceiling for achievement, so worrying about it is a waste of time."

 **Think Big.** Our thinking drives our actions. When we build our lives based on small thinking, we can actually create an artificial ceiling which is hard to break through. Think big, so that your actions will add up to empower rather than restrict you in the future.

 **Don't order from the menu.** Since none of us know our true limits, we don't know what is really impossible or unrealistic. Dare to imagine outcomes that others don't see, so you can make your own creations. To trigger your imagination, try studying people who have achieved what you want, and start from there.

 **Act bold.** Don't just think big. Take bold actions to bring the thoughts to life.

 **Don't fear failure.** Adopt a growth mindset to make failure a part of your learning process, helping to take you to your true potential.

The Truth: The Simple Path to Productivity

1. The Focusing Question

The quality of our questions determine the quality of our answers. By asking the Focusing Question, you drive yourself to make the best possible decisions. You'll need to ask this question over and over again - it will lead to your first domino, then the next, and the next.

- **Ask the Focusing Question: "What's the ONE Thing I can do such that by doing it, everything else will be easier or unnecessary?"**
 - *ONE Thing*: Pick only 1 (not 2 or 3) most important thing.
 - *Can do*: take that possible action. It's not "should do", "could do", or "would do".
 - *By doing it, everything else is easier or unnecessary*: Focus on leveraged action (the first domino) and avoid distractions.
- **Ask this question to define both:**
 -  **The big picture:** Define the direction for your life and what the basket of your life should look like.

KEY QUOTES

"Success requires action, and action requires thought... the only actions that become springboards to succeeding are those informed by big thinking to begin with."

"On the journey to achieving big, you get bigger... What seemed an insurmountable mountain from a distance is just a small hill when you arrive - at least in proportion to the person you've become."

"The Focusing Question is a big-picture map and small-focus compass."

"The Focusing Question asks you to find the first domino and focus on it exclusively until you knock it over. Once you've done that, you'll discover a line of dominoes behind it either ready to fall or already down."

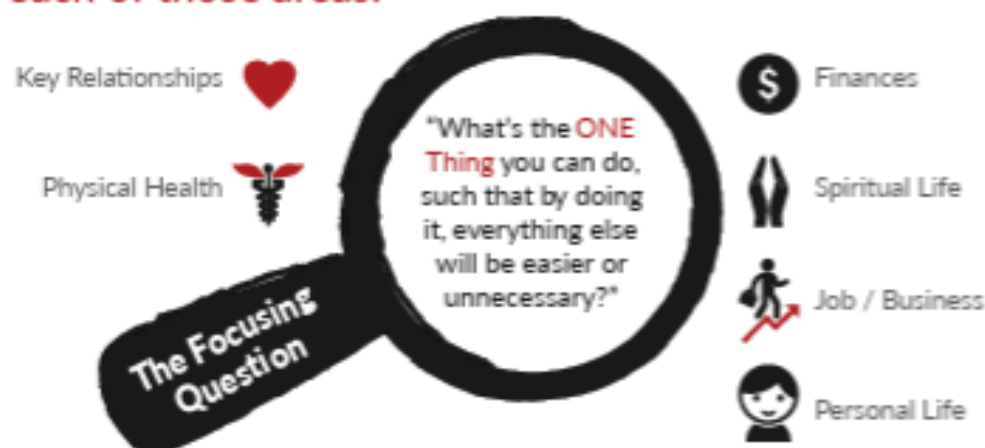


The small focus: Identify the smallest next move you should take immediately.



2. The Success Habit

Asking the Focusing Question is the most powerful foundational habit that you can use to lead an extraordinary life. **Apply it only to important areas of your life, and use it to create the greatest impact in each of those areas.**



To make it a part of your daily routine:

- **Understand and believe it:** You must buy into the concept to use it.
- **Use it:** Start each day with the Focusing Question.
- **Make it a habit:** Keep doing it until it becomes a part of your routine.
- **Leverage reminders:** Set up ways to remind yourself that until your ONE Thing is one, everything else is a distraction.
- **Use it:** Get others around you to practice the Success Habit daily with you.



3. The Path to Great Answers



Think Big & Specific: When asking the Focusing Question, use a Big and Specific placeholder (e.g. big goal with concrete numbers and timeframe) of where you want to be.



Think Possibilities: The answers to your questions come in 3 categories:

- Doable: What you know and can achieve.
- Stretch: At the limits of your current ability.
- Possibility: Beyond what is already known & being done.

A Great Answer explores the 3rd category - what is possible.

KEY QUOTES

"Whether you seek answers big or small, asking the Focusing Question is the ultimate success habit for your life."

"If you're not serious about learning the Success Habit, you're not serious about getting extraordinary results."

"A Great Answer is essentially a new answer. It is a leap across all current answers in search of the next one."



Benchmark and trend for the best answer:

To find a Great Answer, your ONE Thing is to search for clues and role models by researching and studying high achievers. You need to do both benchmarking (for today's successes) and trending (for tomorrow's successes). Be prepared to reinvent yourself to create the new possibilities you envisage.

Achieving Extraordinary Results



Live with Purpose, to get Extraordinary Results

Productivity (and profits in business) are driven by 2 areas:



Your Big ONE Thing = **your purpose**.



Your Small ONE Thing = **your priority** (that you take action on).



Tap into your purpose and allow it to direct your priorities. With clear priorities, you can get to work on what matters. **When where you want to go is aligned with what you**

do today, extraordinary results will happen. When you have a bigger purpose and you are fulfilling it through what you do daily, you will also achieve lasting happiness. **Use the ONE Thing to identify your Big Why, and what you can do now to start fulfilling it.** If you don't have an answer yet, simply pick a direction, start on the path, and refine it over time as you get more clarity.

Live by Priority

- **Have only ONE priority now.**
- **Goal-set to the Now**, by connecting your goal and priority today to your weekly, monthly, one-year, five-year and someday goals. Research shows that the farther away a reward is in the future, the smaller the immediate motivation to achieve it. To improve your motivation, start by defining your "Someday Goal", then apply the Focusing Question

KEY QUOTES

"Connecting purpose, priority and productivity determines how high above the rest successful individuals and profitable businesses rise."

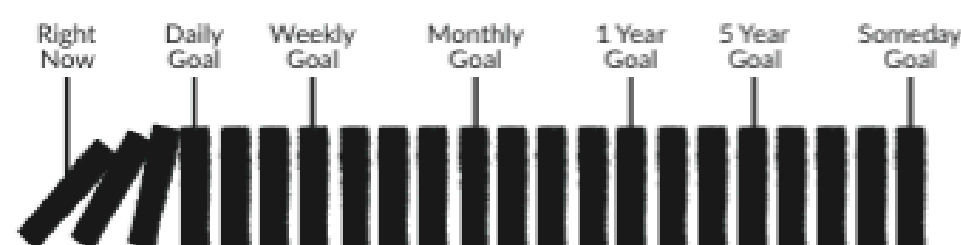
"Who we are and where we want to go determine what we do and what we accomplish."

"Happiness happens on the way to fulfillment...When our daily actions fulfill a bigger purpose, the most powerful and enduring happiness can happen"

"At any moment in time there can only be ONE Thing, and when that ONE Thing is in line with your purpose and sits atop your priorities, it will be the most productive thing you can do to launch you towards the best you can be."

"Connect today to all your tomorrows. It matters."

backward progressively to the ONE Thing you need to do, right now.



- Put these goals down on paper, and keep them close.

Live for Productivity

Time Blocking

Time blocking helps us to ensure what has to get done actually gets done. There are 3 things to Time-Block for (in this order):

 **Time off.** Resting is as important as working. Block out time for vacations and rest, because you know you need and can afford it.

1 Your ONE Thing. Set aside regular time as early in the day as possible to get your ONE Thing done. Keller recommends that you:

- Set aside 30min-1 hour to take care of your morning priorities, then block **4 hours a day** for your ONE Thing.
- Separate “maker time” (chunks of time to develop ideas, write, recruit people etc.) from “manager time” (e.g. cluster meetings together to avoid fragmented activities).

Once you have finished your ONE Thing for the day, you can devote the rest of your time to everything else.

 **Planning Time.** Block **an hour each week** to review your annual and monthly goals (using the Focusing Question to identify what matters most).

The key is to get an unbroken chain of productivity going (by **acting on your ONE Thing daily**) and allow momentum and motivation to take over from there.

 **Once you have blocked your time, protect it at all costs.** Don't allow anything/ anyone to move them. To protect your time blocks:

KEY QUOTES

“Even if you’re on the right track, you’ll get run over if you just sit there.”
- Will Rogers -

“Great success shows up when time is devoted every day to becoming great.”

“If you don’t time block each day to do your ONE Thing, your ONE Thing won’t become a done thing.”

- **Build a bunker:** Have a physical place where you can work with a "Do Not Disturb" sign.
- **Store provisions:** Have all necessary supplies and materials handy so you don't need to leave your bunker.
- **Give 100% attention:** Switch off your phone, shut down your emails and internet browser etc. so you can focus fully on your ONE Thing.
- **Enlist support:** Inform those who may seek you out during the time block, so they know when they can access you.

The Three Commitments

Time-blocking alone is not enough. **You need 3 key commitments:**

A Follow the Path of Mastery. Mastery is a commitment to becoming your best. It is a never-ending journey - see it as a path to embark on, rather than a destination to arrive at. As you gain mastery, your self-confidence and success competence will grow, and you find each successive domino easier to conquer.

Move from "E" to "P". Don't just do the best you can (the "Entrepreneurial approach"). Do the best way it can be done (the "Productive approach"). Using the "P" approach means constantly narrowing down your choices to what you should do, and focusing on those choices, even if feels unnatural. That way, you get the most results out of your effort.

Hold yourself accountable for achieving your ONE Thing. Take complete ownership for your outcomes. This involves seeking and acknowledging reality, then taking ownership to find and execute the best solution. Don't fight reality nor be a victim of circumstances. To accelerate the process, find an "accountability partner" e.g. a mentor or coach.

Manage the 4 Thieves of Productivity

Start saying "no": It's not possible to please everyone. Say "yes" to your ONE Thing (and consider requests related to that priority). Say "no" to everything else.

KEY QUOTES

"Mastery actually means you're a master of what you know and an apprentice of what you don't."

"Focus is a matter of deciding what things you're not going to do."
- John Carmack -

"If you can't say no a lot, you'll never truly be able to say yes to achieving your ONE Thing."

"When you strive for greatness, chaos is guaranteed to show up."

 **Accept chaos:** When you focus on your ONE Thing, other stuff will inevitably pile up. Don't fight the mess or chaos. Trust that commitment to your main priority will, over time, yield the results that will prove you made the right decisions.

 **Manage your energy:** Good personal energy management is foundational to productivity. This includes spiritual, physical, emotional, mental and business energies. The secret is to spend the early hours of your day energizing yourself, so you have what you need for the day.

 **Take ownership of your environment.** Your environment includes who you see (people) and what you experience (place). Make sure these are aligned with and support your ONE Thing.

Conclusion

Extraordinary results don't happen overnight. They are built sequentially, one step at a time. By using the Focusing Question to survey and narrow down your options, line up your priorities and do what matters most, you are setting yourself up for success and a life with no regrets. Your ONE Thing now is to identify the ONE Thing you can do to get started on this journey – and do it.

Other details to look out for in the book

The book comes with several practical examples and illustrations to help readers understand the concept of the ONE Thing and how to apply it. You can visit www.the1thing.com for additional resources.

About the Author & Co-Author of The One Thing

Gary Keller is an American author and a real estate entrepreneur. He has been working in real estate for over 30 years, and is the founder and chairman of the board for Keller Williams Realty, the largest real estate franchise in

KEY QUOTES

"When you clear the path to success – that's when you consistently get there."

"Your journey toward extraordinary results will be built above all else on faith... Faith ultimately leads to action."

"Actions build on action. Habits build on habit. Success builds on success. The right domino knocks down another and another and another. So whenever you want extraordinary results, look for the levered action that will start a domino run for you."